

Rampur Raza Library, a.k.a. 'kitabkhana'

SHUTTERSTOCK

EAT, READ, LOVE

In Rampur, everything from the Raza Library to the shop selling jalebis has aged gracefully

By **AMIT DIXIT**

If you watch a certain vintage of Bollywood film, chances are you would have heard of the Rampuri *chaaku*. Perhaps, you've crossed paths with a Rampuri kabab at a culinary pop-up, or you might even be a cynophile given to slavering over the Rampur greyhound.

That said, it is likelier you're still waiting to discover the delights of this former princely state, lying 200 km east of Delhi, just beyond Moradabad. The state of Rampur was formed in 1774 by Nawab Faizullah Khan, a Rohilla Pathan, under British protection. The Nawab wanted to name the city he was founding Faizabad, after himself. However, since there were many other places known by that name, he had to content himself with Mustafabad. Sadly, for the Nawab, it's really the name Rampur that has stuck.

The first Nawab left an impressive architectural legacy behind. He built the Rampur Fort and the sprawling Imambara within it, as well as a grand mosque, the Jama Masjid. He was also a great patron of scholarship, and began collecting manuscripts in Arabic, Persian, Turkish and Urdu. These now make up the bulk of the collection at the Rampur Raza Library. Managed by the government, the '*kitabkhana*' as it is called, lies inside the fort and houses an impressive repository of Indo-Islamic cultural heritage, with more than 12,000 rare manuscripts and a fine collection of Mughal miniatures. Inside the library complex lies the 1905-built Durbar Hall, or Hamid Manzil, which also houses a museum.

Rampur has a few other sights—Gandhi Samadhi, Mumtaz Park and Ambedkar Park among them. While the legendary cuisine of the Nawabs of Rampur, cooked in clay pots, may be a rarity these days—the *taar gosht korma* (mutton slow-cooked in a rich marrow gravy) is said to be the signature dish of the royal kitchen of Rampur, while unusual desserts like *subz meetha* and *adrak ka halwa* inspire more adulation than raised eyebrows—you can still have jalebi from a 150-year-old shop or a metre-long seekh kabab in Rampur. ■

RAMPUR
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Decades of Perfection

